

■ By Malini Bhupta

For seven-year-old Gopal Tanaji Vanwe, home is not one place. With his parents, migrant farm labourers, Gopal moves from district to district. It's Beed one season, Jalgaon in another. Millions of nomadic families such as his are not covered by the National Sample Survey. Given that none of these families live in one place

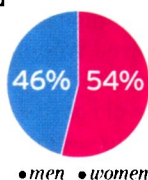
basic LESSON

★ **Pravin Mahajan, 54**

Project Educating children of migrant labourers

Can-do Icon The common man who knows that he can do with an extra pair of hands in the fields, but still wants to ensure good education for his children

In 1991, **39 million** people migrated from rural to urban areas, of which 54 per cent were women



for more than a few months, the Government's largesse evades them, whether it is primary education for their children or shelter for themselves.

But thanks to one man's efforts at providing these children with a choice, Gopal and many of his friends now happily recite rhymes and tables under a tree in a remote village in Bhenda (Maharashtra). Founded by Pravin Mahajan, Janarth, a not-for-profit organisation operating in Maharashtra, has come up with an innovative alternative education solution for children of seasonal migrants.

Almost 6.5 lakh families with 2 lakh children migrate to sugarcane cooperatives in Maharashtra alone. Given that the sugarcane harvesting season starts in April, which coincides with the academic year, most children of migrant parents are left out of the education system even if there is a school in the village they come from. So in 2000, Janarth took it upon itself to address their needs. After much cajoling, the first sakhar shala or sugar school was born at the Mula sugarcane factory in Naggar district, which now provides primary education to children of migrant farm labourers. Janarth's 126 sakhar shalas across 39 sugar factories in Maharashtra now cover 15,000 children. To ensure that older children don't have to drop out of school in their critical years, Janarth also built hostels in the villages from where families migrate so that children can stay back even

if their parents move.

These educational institutions provide oral learning to children from pre-school to Class VII. The sugar factories allot land for schools and a labour officer appointed by the sugar factory supervises the running. The factory education board is represented by parents, the district education officer and senior factory officials. These schools are close to factories so that parents can look up on their kids whenever they want. Explains Mahajan: "We wanted to give children the freedom to choose a better life. Under the Sarva Siksha Abhiyan, there is a provision for alternative education formats. Sakhar shalas are partially funded (about Rs 30 lakh per year) under that scheme."

Children at these schools get books, slates and even a mid-day snack as an incentive. Through the sakhar shalas scheme, sugarcane cooperatives receive financial incentives from the Government to set up on-site sugar schools, thereby creating a win-win situation for all stakeholders. Currently, Janarth spends up to Rs 1,100 per child, which includes snacks, books and additional educational material.

Children like Gopal may not be able to read or write their names but can recite nursery rhymes like "Johnny, Johnny..." and tables effortlessly, while older children can explain the complex chemical process of sublimation with ease. The schools deliver learning that is relevant to the context of village children, which is